Forces (CAPF) and Ministries, commensurate to their rank and service, also came up for discussion but was turned down every time. We had proposed that 10 per cent of the Agniveers being demobilized be absorbed into various organizations and Ministries. This issue was not new, having even been part of the Seventh Central Pay Commission recommendations.[3] On each occasion, it had been turned down for some specious reason or the other. This time around, it was stated that the ethos of the Armed Forces and paramilitary forces, other CAPF and even the State police forces was different, and hence the Agniveers would not be suitable for lateral induction. On the one hand, these were supposed to be the youth who had negotiated the 'Agnipath' in the service of the nation, and now suddenly they were 'unsuitable'. Obviously, vested interests were at play. Our recommendations did not find favour and the scheme was announced without any mention of lateral induction. In the uproar that followed after the announcement of the scheme, one of the first amendments that was made, barely four days later on 18 June 2022, was the reservation of 10 per cent vacancies in the CAPFs and Assam Rifles for Agniveers.[4] Sometimes, it is good to listen to the advice of the Service Chiefs. This is, unfortunately, not the end of the story. Reports are now coming out that the Agniveers will have to undergo fresh entrance tests and will be absorbed only if they clear these tests.[5] Entrance test? For someone who was selected in the first instance through the most rigorous process and with four years of service under his belt? Obviously, grounds are now being prepared on how to get out of this *jhamela* of lateral induction.

There were countless meetings at different levels to thrash out points of divergence. While we were able to prevail on most, we had to concede ground on others, especially on the issue of retention percentages. Win some, lose some. On

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